WOMEN'S QUOTA BILL

COVER STORY

IN

1925, delivering a speech at a women's conference in Gujarat's Sojitra village, Mahatma Gandhi had said: "As long as the women of India do not take part in public life, there can be no salvation for the country." Nearly a century later, the Narendra Modi government has sought to institutionalise women's participation in public life at the highest level by introducing the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam (Salutation to Women Power Bill), which will reserve a third of the seats in the Lok Sabha and the state assemblies for women. With five states going to the polls this year and the general election coming up next year, the bill has been timed to directly appeal to women voters, who have been the backbone of the BJP's electoral success in the past decade. True to his style, the PM caught the Opposition parties off-guard, forcing them to become grudging cheerleaders even as the BJP goes to town cornering credit for a legislation that aims to be a game-changer in electoral politics.

With India's abysmally poor record in women's representation in Parliament and state legislatures, this bill has been waiting to see the light of day for nearly three decades. In the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Index, which maps the gender gap in countries across four dimensions—economic opportunities, education, health and political leadership—India has consistently ranked below 100 out of nearly 150 countries. An April 2023 report by the McKinsey Global Institute estimated that India could add up to $770 billion, or more than 18 per cent, to its GDP by 2025 if it gave its women equal opportunities. Currently, women's contribution to the country's GDP is just 18 per cent, among the lowest in the world, with only 25 per cent of India's labour force being female.



Though the share of women MPs in the Lok Sabha has risen from 4 per cent in 1952 to nearly 15 per cent in 2019, it remains far below the global average of 26 per cent. The share is similar in the Upper House but it goes down to sub-10 per cent in 19 states. This is despite the sharp rise in political awareness among women courtesy the 33 per cent reservation introduced in Panchayati Raj institutions in 1993. This share goes up to 50 per cent in 21 states. With the women's reservation bill, India will join the select club of around 40 nations, including neighbours Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and China, that have reserved seats for women in legislative bodies.

The impact of the bill can be gauged from just one simple hypothetical calculation: if implemented today, the number of women MPs in the Lok Sabha will jump to at least 180, from the current 82. "Let's remember India has been repeatedly classified as a flawed democracy in global democracy indices and the abysmal